Neural Oscillation Signature Theory: Theoretical Foundations

Randolph R. Beverly Jr.

Beverly Index LLC

Author Note

Randolph R. Beverly Jr., Beverly Index LLC, Cheyenne, Wyoming, United States.

The author is the founder and president of Beverly Index LLC, a company developing commercial applications based on the theoretical framework presented in this paper. This potential conflict of interest is disclosed in accordance with APA ethical standards. The theoretical framework presented herein is offered for scientific scrutiny and empirical testing by the research community.

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Randolph R. Beverly Jr., Beverly Index LLC. Email: contact@beverlyindex.com

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Abstract

This paper introduces Neural Oscillation Signature Theory (NOST), a theoretical framework proposing that cognitive states can be inferred from linguistic output because neural oscillatory patterns systematically shape language production. The framework integrates established findings from cognitive neuroscience—particularly research on neural oscillations and their role in memory, attention, executive function, and emotional regulation—with insights from psycholinguistics regarding the cognitive processes underlying language production. The central theoretical claim is that the statistical properties of linguistic output (lexical, syntactic, semantic, temporal, and prosodic features) carry extractable information about the neural oscillatory configuration present during language generation. This paper articulates five core theoretical propositions, derives specific testable hypotheses organized by oscillatory frequency band, proposes the NOST Information Principle as a formal statement of the framework's foundational assumption, introduces the concept of Psychological Lense-Thirring Precession as a model for tracking cognitive integration dynamics, and discusses implications for cognitive assessment. The framework is offered as a theoretical contribution warranting empirical investigation rather than an established finding.

Keywords: neural oscillations, language production, cognitive assessment, linguistic signatures, oscillatory-linguistic mapping, NOST, information theory, Lense-Thirring precession

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Neural Oscillation Signature Theory: Theoretical Foundations

The relationship between mind and language has occupied philosophers and scientists for centuries. Language serves as the primary window through which internal mental states become externally observable. Yet despite significant advances in cognitive neuroscience and psycholinguistics, no comprehensive theoretical framework exists for systematically inferring cognitive states from the structural properties of linguistic output.

This paper proposes such a framework: Neural Oscillation Signature Theory (NOST). The central claim is that neural oscillatory patterns—rhythmic electrical activity across distributed brain networks—systematically influence language production in ways that leave detectable traces in linguistic output. If this claim is correct, careful analysis of language could provide a non-invasive method for inferring the cognitive processes that generated it.

The present paper is explicitly theoretical. It integrates established empirical findings into a novel framework and derives testable predictions. Empirical validation remains to be conducted. The framework is offered to the scientific community for scrutiny, critique, and empirical investigation.

Empirical Foundations

Neural Oscillations and Cognitive Function

Neural oscillations are among the most robust phenomena in cognitive neuroscience. Rhythmic electrical activity, generated by the synchronized firing of neuronal populations, occurs across multiple frequency bands, each associated with distinct cognitive operations. This section reviews the evidence linking specific oscillatory bands to cognitive functions relevant to language production.

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Delta oscillations (0.5–4 Hz).

Delta-band activity is associated with motivational processing, deep sleep homeostasis, and large-scale cortical integration. During wakefulness, delta oscillations have been linked to motivational salience detection (Knyazev, 2007) and inhibitory control (Harmony, 2013). In pathological states, elevated delta activity during wakefulness is associated with traumatic brain injury, neurodegenerative conditions, and encephalopathy (Niedermeyer & da Silva, 2005). For the purposes of the present framework, delta-band activity is predicted to influence the global coherence and motivational framing of linguistic output.

Theta oscillations (4–8 Hz).

Theta oscillations play a central role in memory encoding and retrieval, particularly in hippocampal-cortical circuits (Nyhus & Curran, 2010). Theta power increases during successful memory formation (Hanslmayr et al., 2016), spatial navigation (Buzsaki & Moser, 2013), and working memory maintenance (Sauseng et al., 2010). Theta phase has been shown to coordinate the timing of memory reactivation events. For the present framework, theta-band activity is predicted to influence memory-dependent linguistic features including autobiographical detail, temporal reference accuracy, and episodic specificity.

Alpha oscillations (8–12 Hz).

Alpha oscillations are associated with attentional gating and inhibitory control. The prevailing view is that alpha activity reflects functional inhibition of task-irrelevant cortical regions (Jensen & Mazaheri, 2010; Klimesch, 2012). Alpha desynchronization in task-relevant regions facilitates information processing, while alpha synchronization in irrelevant regions suppresses competing information. Disruptions to alpha dynamics are observed in anxiety disorders (increased frontal alpha asymmetry; Thibodeau et al., 2006), depression (reduced left

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frontal alpha power), and attentional disorders. For the present framework, alpha-band activity is predicted to influence attentional markers in linguistic output, including topic maintenance, information selection, and the balance between internally and externally oriented content.

Beta oscillations (12–30 Hz).

Beta oscillations are associated with motor planning, sensorimotor integration, and maintenance of the current cognitive set (Engel & Fries, 2010). In the context of language, beta activity has been linked to syntactic processing (Lewis et al., 2015) and predictive coding during sentence comprehension (Weiss & Mueller, 2012). Pathological beta-band activity is a hallmark of Parkinson's disease, reflecting dysfunction in basal ganglia–cortical circuits (Little & Brown, 2014). For the present framework, beta-band activity is predicted to influence syntactic complexity, motor-speech characteristics (articulation rate, fluency), sequential planning in discourse, and the maintenance of coherent narrative structure.

Gamma oscillations (30–100 Hz).

Gamma oscillations are associated with perceptual binding, conscious awareness, and the integration of distributed representations (Fries, 2009). Gamma synchrony enables the binding of features processed in different cortical regions into unified percepts. Reduced gamma-band synchrony is one of the most replicated findings in schizophrenia (Uhlhaas & Singer, 2010) and has been linked to the disorganized thought that characterizes the condition. For the present framework, gamma-band activity is predicted to influence semantic coherence, perceptual description fidelity, and the integration of multi-modal information in narrative construction.

Language Production and Cognitive Constraints

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The psycholinguistic literature provides robust evidence that language production is not an autonomous process but is systematically constrained by cognitive operations. Levelt's (1989) seminal model identifies four processing stages—conceptualization, formulation, articulation, and self-monitoring—each of which draws on cognitive resources that are subject to oscillatory governance. Working memory capacity constrains syntactic complexity (Just & Carpenter, 1992). Attentional allocation influences lexical selection (Roelofs, 2003). Executive function governs discourse planning and coherence maintenance (Altmann & Kamide, 1999).

The critical inference for NOST is that if each of these cognitive operations is supported by oscillatory processes, and if disruptions to those oscillatory processes alter the cognitive operations, then the linguistic output produced under different oscillatory configurations should differ in systematic and detectable ways.

Psychiatric Conditions and Linguistic Markers

A growing literature documents linguistic differences associated with psychiatric and neurological conditions. Depression is associated with increased first-person singular pronoun use, negative emotion words, and absolutist language (Al-Mosaiwi & Johnstone, 2018; Rude et al., 2004). Psychotic disorders are associated with reduced semantic coherence, increased referential ambiguity, and tangential discourse (Bedi et al., 2015; Elvevåg et al., 2007). Neurodegenerative conditions produce progressive reductions in syntactic complexity and vocabulary diversity (Fraser et al., 2016; Garrard et al., 2005). PTSD generates fragmented temporal reference, avoidant language around trauma content, and reduced narrative integration (Jaeger et al., 2014).

These findings are compelling but lack a unifying theoretical explanation. NOST proposes that the explanation lies in the oscillatory disruptions that characterize each condition:

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different oscillatory pathologies produce different cognitive processing configurations, which in turn produce different linguistic signatures.

The Five Core Propositions of NOST

Proposition 1: The Oscillatory Governance Principle

Neural oscillatory patterns are not epiphenomenal but play functional, causal roles in organizing cognitive processes relevant to language production. This proposition is supported by the converging evidence reviewed above and by causal intervention studies demonstrating that artificially modulating oscillatory activity (e.g., through transcranial alternating current stimulation) produces corresponding changes in cognitive performance (Herrmann et al., 2013).

Proposition 2: The Linguistic Encoding Principle

The cognitive processes governed by neural oscillations systematically influence language production at multiple levels: lexical selection, syntactic construction, semantic organization, temporal structure, and prosodic characteristics. This proposition is grounded in the psycholinguistic evidence reviewed above, particularly the demonstrated dependence of language production on working memory, attention, executive function, and motor planning—all oscillatorily governed processes.

Proposition 3: The Signature Specificity Principle

Different oscillatory configurations produce distinguishable patterns of linguistic features—referred to as linguistic signatures. These signatures are not random but are structured by the functional roles of the oscillatory bands involved. This is the central predictive claim of NOST: that the mapping from oscillatory states to linguistic features is sufficiently regular to support inference in the reverse direction—from observed linguistic features to inferred

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oscillatory states. A critical corollary of this proposition is that signatures should persist under conditions of psychological stress, distortion, or deliberate concealment—degraded in fidelity, perhaps, but not obliterated. Recent findings in quantum chromodynamics provide a striking physical precedent: quarkonia—bound states of heavy quark-antiquark pairs—survive as detectable resonances within quark-gluon plasma at temperatures far exceeding the point at which they were expected to dissolve (Bauer et al., 2025). The signature is distorted by the extreme environment but not destroyed. If bound-state resonances persist under conditions of extreme thermal disruption at the subatomic scale, the analogous persistence of cognitive-linguistic signatures under conditions of psychological stress is not merely plausible but consistent with a broader physical principle regarding the resilience of structured states under perturbation.

Proposition 4: The Clinical Correspondence Principle

Psychiatric and neurological conditions characterized by known oscillatory disruptions should produce linguistic signatures that correspond to those disruptions. The nature of the linguistic changes should be predictable from knowledge of the oscillatory pathology and its known cognitive consequences. This proposition generates the clinically relevant predictions of the framework and is the most directly testable.

Proposition 5: The Treatment Sensitivity Principle

Linguistic signatures should change in response to effective treatment, tracking with changes in the underlying oscillatory pathology and associated cognitive function. This proposition implies that language-based assessment could serve not only diagnostic but also monitoring and prognostic functions.

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The NOST Information Principle

The foundational assumption of NOST can be formalized as an information-theoretic claim: linguistic output carries non-zero mutual information with the internal oscillatory state that generated it. In formal notation: I(Oscillatory State; Linguistic Output) > 0, where I denotes mutual information. This states that knowing the statistical properties of linguistic output reduces uncertainty about the oscillatory state that produced it, and vice versa.

This is, in one sense, a modest claim—it asserts only that some information transfer occurs, not that the transfer is complete or noise-free. Yet its implications are significant: if the mutual information is sufficiently large, then computational extraction of linguistic features can support meaningful inferences about cognitive states. The empirical question is not whether the mutual information is zero—the existing literature strongly suggests it is not—but whether it is large enough to support clinically useful inference.

The Information Principle also illuminates the relationship between NOST and broader information-theoretic principles observed in other scientific domains. The extraction of internal state information from observable output is a problem structure shared across fields: seismology infers Earth's internal structure from surface wave propagation, spectroscopy infers molecular composition from electromagnetic emission patterns, and gravitational wave astronomy infers binary system properties from spacetime perturbations. NOST proposes that the same mathematical structure—inferring hidden generative states from structured observable output—applies to the extraction of cognitive state information from linguistic behavior.

Recent findings in astrophysics and particle physics provide further illustrations of this epistemological structure. The COSMOS-Web gravitational lensing survey, the largest contiguous dark matter map to date, demonstrates that invisible mass distributions—undetectable

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through direct observation—determine where visible galactic structures form across cosmic filaments (Chakraborty et al., 2025; Moneti et al., 2025). The organizing architecture is hidden; the observable structures are its downstream consequences. This relationship is structurally analogous to NOST's central claim: that unobservable neural oscillatory states constitute the organizing architecture that determines the structure of observable linguistic output. Similarly, the detection of the Amaterasu particle—an ultra-high-energy cosmic ray with energy exceeding 240 exa-electronvolts whose apparent trajectory pointed toward a region of empty space (Telescope Array Collaboration, 2023)—illustrates that the most energetic signals can arrive from sources invisible to conventional observation. Subsequent analysis suggests that the particle's apparent origin in the Local Void was an artifact of trajectory deflection through intervening extragalactic magnetic fields, with the actual source likely a nearby star-forming galaxy (Capel & Bourriche, 2026). The deflection problem—in which intervening forces bend a signal's apparent trajectory, making it appear to originate from a different source than its true one—is precisely the inferential challenge that NOST-based assessment must address when interpreting linguistic output produced under conditions of deliberate narrative management or psychological defense.

These analogies are offered as structural parallels, not claims about shared physical substrates. NOST does not claim that neural oscillations are quantum phenomena or that cognitive processes operate by the same mechanisms as gravitational lensing. The argument is epistemological: that the inference of hidden generative states from structured observable output is a well-established and productive scientific methodology, and that NOST's application of this methodology to the cognitive-linguistic domain is consistent with a broad class of successful scientific frameworks.

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Psychological Lense-Thirring Precession: A Model for Integration Dynamics

A novel extension of NOST addresses the temporal dynamics of cognitive processing following significant psychological events. This extension draws a formal analogy to the Lense-Thirring effect in general relativity, wherein the spin of a massive rotating body (such as a black hole) produces a frame-dragging effect on nearby orbiting matter, causing measurable precession in accretion disk dynamics.

In the psychological domain, we propose that when significant new material—whether traumatic experience, major life transition, or therapeutically recovered content—encounters the individual's core psychological processing architecture, it produces a measurable perturbation in linguistic output patterns that dampens over time as integration proceeds. Specifically, the linguistic features tracked by NOST should exhibit periodic fluctuations following a significant psychological event, with the amplitude of these fluctuations decreasing as the material is successfully integrated into the individual's cognitive framework.

This model generates several testable predictions. First, the frequency and amplitude of linguistic oscillatory perturbations following a significant event should be measurable in serial language samples. Second, successful therapeutic processing should correlate with faster damping of these perturbations. Third, the pattern of perturbation—which NOSS sectors show the greatest fluctuation—should correspond to the nature of the psychological material being processed. Fourth, stalled integration (as in complex PTSD or unresolved grief) should manifest as sustained oscillatory perturbations that fail to dampen over expected timescales.

The analogy to Lense-Thirring precession is offered as a conceptual and mathematical framework rather than a claim about shared physical mechanisms. The utility of the analogy lies in its precise mathematical characterization of damped oscillatory dynamics following

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perturbation—a pattern that, if observed in longitudinal linguistic data, would provide strong support for NOST's predictions about the temporal dynamics of cognitive processing.

An additional consideration for assessment timing emerges from recent particle physics research on post-collision structure formation. Studies of heavy-ion collisions at CERN have demonstrated that fragile nuclear structures such as deuterons do not survive the extreme temperatures of the collision fireball itself; rather, they form during the subsequent cooling phase through the decay of ultra-short-lived high-energy resonance states (Andronic et al., 2025). The diagnostically relevant structure crystallizes after the acute event, not during it. This finding carries a potential implication for NOST-based assessment: the most coherent and diagnostically informative linguistic signatures may emerge not during acute psychological crisis—when cognitive processing is maximally disrupted—but during the consolidation period that follows, as the individual's cognitive architecture begins to reorganize around the new material. If confirmed empirically, this would suggest that assessment timing is a critical methodological variable, and that narrative samples collected during the post-acute integration window may yield more reliable oscillatory-linguistic signatures than those collected during peak distress.

Specific Predictions Organized by Oscillatory Band

Delta-Band Predictions

Conditions characterized by elevated waking delta activity (traumatic brain injury, neurodegenerative conditions, encephalopathy) should produce reduced global narrative coherence, diminished thematic integration across discourse segments, and impoverished motivational framing. Conversely, healthy delta function should be associated with well-integrated narratives with clear motivational structure and global thematic coherence.

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Theta-Band Predictions

Conditions involving theta-band disruption (hippocampal pathology, memory disorders, PTSD-related memory fragmentation) should produce reduced episodic specificity in autobiographical narratives, impoverished temporal reference, and diminished contextual detail. Authentic memory recall should produce theta-associated linguistic features that differ systematically from constructed or fabricated narratives, as the cognitive processes underlying genuine retrieval (hippocampal theta-mediated reactivation) differ from those underlying deliberate construction.

Alpha-Band Predictions

Conditions involving alpha-band dysregulation (anxiety disorders, attentional disorders, certain depressive subtypes) should produce altered attentional markers in linguistic output: increased hypervigilance-related content in anxiety, reduced information selection efficiency in attentional disorders, and shifts in the balance between internally and externally oriented content. Frontal alpha asymmetry patterns associated with depression should correspond to altered emotional valence in lexical selection.

Beta-Band Predictions

Conditions involving pathological beta-band activity (Parkinson's disease, certain motor disorders, executive dysfunction) should produce measurable changes in both motor-speech characteristics (reduced articulation rate, altered voice quality, increased dysfluency) and cognitive-linguistic features (reduced syntactic complexity, impoverished action language, diminished sequential planning in discourse). The beta-band prediction for Parkinson's disease is particularly specific: the known pathological beta oscillations in basal ganglia–cortical circuits should manifest as a distinctive combined motor-speech and cognitive-linguistic signature.

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Gamma-Band Predictions

Conditions involving reduced gamma-band synchrony (schizophrenia, certain dissociative states) should produce measurable reductions in semantic coherence, impoverished perceptual description, and reduced integration of multi-modal information in narrative construction. The gamma-band prediction for schizophrenia is among the most directly testable, given the robust evidence for gamma-band deficits in this condition and the well-documented linguistic disorganization that accompanies it.

Methodological Requirements for Empirical Validation

Validating NOST requires a structured program of empirical research with several components. First, concurrent measurement studies must establish whether the proposed oscillatory–linguistic mappings hold: simultaneous EEG recording during standardized language production tasks, with correlation analysis between oscillatory power spectra and computational linguistic features of the output. Second, clinical validation studies must determine whether the predicted condition-specific linguistic signatures are observed in populations with confirmed diagnoses. Third, longitudinal treatment studies must test whether linguistic signatures change in response to effective intervention.

Each of these study types presents methodological challenges. Concurrent measurement requires careful control of movement artifacts during EEG recording while participants produce language—a task that inherently involves motor activity. Clinical validation requires large, well-characterized patient samples with diagnosis established through gold-standard methods. Longitudinal studies require sustained participant engagement and appropriate statistical methods for modeling within-person change over time.

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Additionally, the framework must demonstrate discriminant validity: that the proposed oscillatory–linguistic mappings are specific enough to distinguish between conditions with overlapping symptomatology. It must also demonstrate robustness across languages, cultures, age groups, and educational levels—all factors known to influence linguistic output independently of cognitive pathology.

An early-stage pilot implementation of principles related to this framework has been deployed in a clinical setting outside Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, through a proprietary system developed by the author's company. While formal results from this deployment are not yet available for peer-reviewed reporting, the clinical feedback has been sufficiently encouraging to motivate the present theoretical exposition. Independent replication by researchers without commercial interest will be essential for establishing the framework's scientific validity.

Relationship to Existing Theoretical Frameworks

NOST relates to but is distinct from several existing theoretical frameworks. Communication dynamics approaches (Fusaroli et al., 2014) examine linguistic coordination between interlocutors but do not propose specific oscillatory mechanisms. Computational approaches to psychiatric language analysis (Corcoran et al., 2018) apply NLP methods to clinical prediction but typically lack mechanistic theory explaining why linguistic features should vary with clinical status. Oscillatory theories of cognition (Engel et al., 2001; Fries, 2005) provide the neuroscientific foundation for NOST but have not previously been extended to make specific predictions about linguistic output.

NOST's distinctive contribution is the integration of these streams into a unified framework that proposes specific, testable mappings between oscillatory bands and classes of

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linguistic features, grounded in the known functional roles of each band and mediated by the established cognitive processes underlying language production.

Limitations and Caveats

Several significant limitations should be acknowledged. First, the proposed oscillatory–linguistic mappings are derived from integrating two separate literatures (oscillatory neuroscience and clinical psycholinguistics) that have rarely been studied in conjunction. The predicted relationships, while theoretically motivated, may not hold when directly tested. Second, the framework as currently stated does not fully specify the interactions between oscillatory bands—cognitive processes involve coordinated activity across multiple frequencies, and the linguistic consequences of these interactions are complex. Third, individual differences in baseline oscillatory profiles and linguistic style represent a potential confound that the framework does not yet adequately address.

Fourth, the author's dual role as theoretical proposer and commercial developer of applications based on this framework creates an inherent bias that the scientific community should weigh appropriately. Fifth, the present paper does not include formal mathematical derivations of the proposed mappings, though a companion mathematical foundations document is in preparation. The predictions stated here are qualitative; quantitative parameterization awaits empirical data.

Conclusion

Neural Oscillation Signature Theory proposes that the statistical properties of linguistic output carry extractable information about the neural oscillatory states that generated them. This claim rests on three well-supported empirical observations: that oscillatory activity functionally governs cognitive processes, that cognitive processes systematically shape language production,

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and that computational methods can extract subtle statistical regularities from linguistic data. The novel contribution is the integration of these observations into a framework that derives specific, testable predictions about which linguistic features should be affected by which oscillatory disruptions.

The introduction of Psychological Lense-Thirring Precession extends the framework into the temporal domain, proposing a quantitative model for how linguistic signatures should evolve during psychological integration—a prediction with significant implications for treatment monitoring if validated.

Whether these predictions prove correct is an empirical question. The present paper provides the theoretical foundation; the empirical program required to test it has been outlined. The scientific community's engagement—through replication, critique, and independent investigation—is both essential and welcomed.

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